

Political Participation and Trust in Political Institutions: A Comparative Analysis of Sweden, Germany, Poland, and Italy

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Abstract

This study examines the relationship between political participation and trust in political institutions across Germany, Italy, Poland, and Sweden using data from Round 11 of the European Social Survey (ESS). It distinguishes between institutionalised forms of participation, including voting, contacting political representatives, and political party activity, and non-institutionalised forms, including petitions, demonstrations, boycotts, and online political engagement. Trust in parliament, politicians, political parties, and the legal system is examined using descriptive analysis, Kruskal–Wallis tests, binary logistic regression models, country fixed effects, political-interest interaction models, and exploratory factor analysis. The results show that voting and political party activity are consistently associated with higher institutional trust, whereas online political engagement is consistently associated with lower trust. Other forms of non-institutionalised participation show mixed relationships across the four institutional outcomes. Substantial cross-national differences are also observed, with Sweden displaying higher institutional trust and Poland lower institutional trust relative to Germany after accounting for individual characteristics and political participation. Greater political interest is associated with higher institutional trust, but political interest does not consistently moderate the relationship between participation and trust. Overall, the findings demonstrate that the relationship between political participation and institutional trust depends on the form of participation, the institution being evaluated, and the national context. The study highlights the importance of distinguishing among different modes of political participation when examining citizens' relationships with democratic institutions.

Keywords: political trust; political participation; institutional trust; European Social Survey; political interest; Europe

1. Introduction

Political trust is an important component of democratic governance because it reflects citizens' confidence in political institutions and the actors responsible for public decision-making. At the same time, political participation provides citizens with opportunities to express their preferences, influence political processes, and hold governments accountable. However, political participation has expanded beyond conventional activities such as voting, contacting political representatives, and participating in political parties. Citizens increasingly engage through petitions, demonstrations, boycotts and online political activities. These developments raise an important question about whether different forms of political participation are associated with political trust in the same way.

Previous research distinguishes between institutionalised and non-institutionalised forms of political participation. Institutionalised participation operates through established political channels, including voting, contacting political representatives, and political party activities, whereas non-institutionalised participation includes activities such as demonstrations, petitions, boycotts, and other forms of political activism outside conventional electoral and party structures. This distinction is important because participation through established institutions may be associated with confidence in the political system, while alternative forms of participation may sometimes reflect dissatisfaction with conventional political institutions. At the same time, lower political trust does not necessarily result in political disengagement, as dissatisfied citizens may remain politically active through alternative forms of participation. The relationship between political participation and institutional trust may also differ across national contexts. This study focuses on Sweden, Germany, Poland, and Italy, four European democracies that provide comparative variation in levels of institutional trust and patterns of political participation. Examining these countries together makes it possible to assess whether the relationship between participation and trust remains consistent across different national contexts.

Against this background, the study asks: What is the relationship between political participation and trust in political institutions across different democratic contexts in Europe? Using data from Round 11 of the European Social Survey (ESS), the analysis examines Sweden, Germany, Poland, and Italy and considers trust in four institutional dimensions: parliament, politicians, political parties, and the legal system. Political participation is examined through both institutionalised and non-institutionalised activities, while individual characteristics such as political interest, age, gender, education, religious affiliation, and employment status are incorporated into the analysis.

By examining different forms of participation rather than treating political engagement as a single behaviour, the study seeks to provide a more differentiated understanding of the relationship between citizen participation and institutional trust. The comparative approach

further allows these relationships to be considered across countries with different levels of political trust and institutional development. In doing so, the study builds on earlier research on political trust and participation while using more recent ESS Round 11 data to examine how these relationships appear in contemporary European democracies.

2. Literature Review and Theoretical Framework

2.1 Political Trust and Political Participation

Political trust concerns citizens' confidence in political institutions and their assessment of whether these institutions operate effectively and legitimately. Newton (2007) distinguishes political trust from broader forms of social trust and highlights its importance for understanding citizens' evaluations of political institutions. Political trust is an important element of democratic governance because citizens' attitudes toward institutions can influence how they interact with the political system. However, low political trust does not necessarily imply rejection of democracy or withdrawal from political life. Norris (1999), for example, describes the emergence of critical citizens who support democratic principles while remaining sceptical of the performance of political institutions. Similarly, Rosanvallon (2008) argues that distrust can coexist with active citizenship, particularly when citizens use monitoring, protest, and other forms of political action to demand accountability.

Political participation refers broadly to activities through which citizens seek to influence political processes and public affairs. Traditional forms include voting, contacting political representatives, and involvement in political parties (Verba et al., 1995). However, the repertoire of political participation has expanded beyond conventional electoral and party-based activities (Dalton, 2017). Barnes and Kaase (1979) provide an important basis for distinguishing conventional participation from political actions occurring outside established electoral and party channels. More recent research has examined non-institutionalised forms such as petitions and demonstrations (Marien et al., 2010), while political consumerism, including practices such as boycotting products for political reasons, has also emerged as an important form of participation (Stolle et al., 2005). This study therefore distinguishes between institutionalised participation, including voting, contacting politicians or officials, and political party activities, and non-institutionalised participation, including petitions, demonstrations, boycotts, and online political engagement.

2.2 Political Participation and Institutional Trust

The relationship between political participation and trust is not necessarily uniform across different forms of political engagement. Citizens who participate through established political institutions may do so because they regard these institutions as legitimate and believe that conventional political channels can represent their interests. Conversely, citizens dissatisfied

with established institutions may remain politically active but express their preferences through protests, petitions, boycotts, or other alternative channels rather than withdrawing from politics altogether.

Hooghe and Marien (2013) are particularly relevant to this relationship. Their study of European countries demonstrates the importance of distinguishing between different modes of participation when examining political trust. Rather than assuming that politically active citizens are either generally trusting or generally distrustful, their approach suggests that the relationship depends on the type of participation involved. The present study builds on this perspective by examining institutionalised and non-institutionalised participation using more recent ESS Round 11 data.

Political interest may also influence this relationship. Citizens who are more interested in politics are likely to pay greater attention to political institutions, actors, and government performance. Greater political interest may therefore encourage participation without necessarily producing greater institutional trust. The original study consequently includes political interest both as an individual-level characteristic and as a potential moderator of the relationship between participation and trust.

2.3 Theoretical Expectations and Hypotheses

Drawing on the distinction between institutionalised and non-institutionalised participation, the study expects different forms of political engagement to be associated differently with institutional trust. Participation through established political channels is expected to be positively associated with trust because such activities involve direct engagement with conventional democratic institutions. In contrast, some non-institutionalised activities may be associated with lower institutional trust because they can provide alternative channels for citizens who are dissatisfied with established political processes. Political interest is additionally expected to condition these relationships.

Accordingly, the study tests three hypotheses:

- I. H1: Institutionalised political participation is positively associated with political trust.
- II. H2: Non-institutionalised political participation is negatively associated with political trust.
- III. H3: Political interest moderates the relationship between political participation and political trust.

3. Data and Methodology

3.1 Data and Research Design

The study uses data from Round 11 of the European Social Survey (ESS), a cross-national survey designed to measure attitudes, beliefs, and behavioural patterns across European

populations (ESS ERIC, 2025). The ESS provides cross-national data on political attitudes, social behaviour, and demographic characteristics across European countries. The analysis focuses on Germany, Italy, Poland, and Sweden, which were selected to capture variation in political trust and patterns of political participation across different democratic contexts.

The initial sample consisted of 7,957 respondents across the four countries. Following the treatment of missing observations, 671 cases were excluded, leaving 7,286 observations in the cleaned dataset used for the descriptive analysis. Additional exclusions associated with the variables used in the regression specifications resulted in an analytical sample of 6,796 respondents for the logistic regression models.

The analysis is cross-sectional rather than longitudinal. Earlier findings, particularly those of Hooghe and Marien (2013), are used as a historical point of comparison rather than as an additional survey wave in the statistical analysis.

3.2 Variables and Measurement

Political trust constitutes the dependent variable and is measured using four ESS indicators: trust in parliament (trstprl), trust in politicians (trstplt), trust in political parties (trstprt), and trust in the legal system (trstlgl). Each indicator is originally measured on a scale from 0 to 10. Consistent with the coding implemented in the analysis, the indicators were transformed into binary variables, with scores from 0 to 4 classified as low trust and scores from 5 to 10 classified as high trust.

Political participation represents the main set of independent variables. The participation indicators are classified into institutionalised and non-institutionalised forms. Institutionalised participation includes voting, contacting a politician or public official, and political party activity. Non-institutionalised participation includes signing a petition, participating in a lawful public demonstration, boycotting products, and sharing political content online. These indicators were recoded as binary variables reflecting whether respondents participated in each activity.

Table 1: Variables Used in the Analysis

Dependent variables	Institutional participation	Non-institutional participation	Control variables
Trust in politicians	Voting	Petition	Age
Trust in political parties	Contacting	Demonstration	Gender
Trust in parliament	Political party activity	Boycott	Education
Trust in legal system		Online political	Religion

		sharing	Political interest
			Employment status

Source: Authors' construction based on ESS Round 11

The models also control for individual characteristics that may be associated with political trust, including age, gender, years of education, religious affiliation, political interest, and employment status. Country indicators are included to account for systematic differences among Germany, Italy, Poland, and Sweden. Political interest is additionally interacted with the participation variables to assess whether it moderates the relationship between political participation and institutional trust.

3.3 Analytical Strategy

The empirical analysis proceeds in three stages. First, descriptive statistics are used to examine the distribution of political trust, participation, and respondents' demographic characteristics. Kruskal–Wallis tests are used to assess cross-country differences in the continuous and ordinal measures, while chi-square tests are applied to selected categorical variables.

Second, binary logistic regression models are estimated separately for trust in parliament, politicians, political parties, and the legal system. The models estimate the association between different forms of political participation and the probability of reporting high institutional trust while controlling for demographic and socioeconomic characteristics. Country fixed effects are included to account for cross-national differences. Additional interaction models examine whether the associations between participation and political trust vary according to respondents' level of political interest. Regression results are primarily interpreted using estimated coefficients and statistical significance levels. Odds ratios and average marginal effects are additionally reported for trust in parliament, politicians, and political parties to provide a more intuitive interpretation of selected associations.

Finally, an exploratory factor analysis (EFA) is used to examine whether selected participation and political trust indicators reflect broader underlying dimensions of political engagement and institutional trust. This provides a supplementary assessment of how the different indicators cluster within the data.

4. Results

To keep the paper within the 20-page target, the results are organised around the main empirical patterns rather than reproducing every statistical output from the original presentation. The section first describes the sample and cross-country variation, before

examining the logistic regression results for the four dimensions of institutional trust and the supplementary factor analysis.

4.1 Descriptive and Cross-Country Results

Table 2: Descriptive Statistics of Key Study Variables

Variable	Mean	Median	Minimum	Maximum
Voting	1.293	1	1	3
Contacted politician/official	1.787	2	1	2
Political party activity	1.965	2	1	2
Signed petition	1.763	2	1	2
Participated in demonstration	1.924	2	1	2
Boycotted products	1.775	2	1	2
Shared political content online	1.774	2	1	2
Age (years)	51.40	52	15	90
Years of education	13.46	13	0	50
Gender	1.507	2	1	2
Religious affiliation	1.367	1	1	2
Political interest	2.486	2	1	4
Employment Status	3.138	2	1	9

Source: Authors' analysis of European Social Survey Round 11 data.

Note. The table reports descriptive statistics following the data-cleaning stage. Participation and categorical variables retain their numerical ESS coding at this stage of the analysis and should therefore not be interpreted as continuous measures. The trust variables were subsequently recoded into binary outcomes for the logistic regression analysis. The cleaned sample contained 7,286 observations.

The analysis further examined whether political trust and selected demographic characteristics differed across the four countries. Kruskal–Wallis tests showed statistically significant cross-country differences for all four measures of institutional trust. Trust in parliament differed significantly across countries ($\chi^2 = 645.54$, $p < .001$), as did trust in politicians ($\chi^2 = 537.02$, $p < .001$), political parties ($\chi^2 = 617.14$, $p < .001$), and the legal

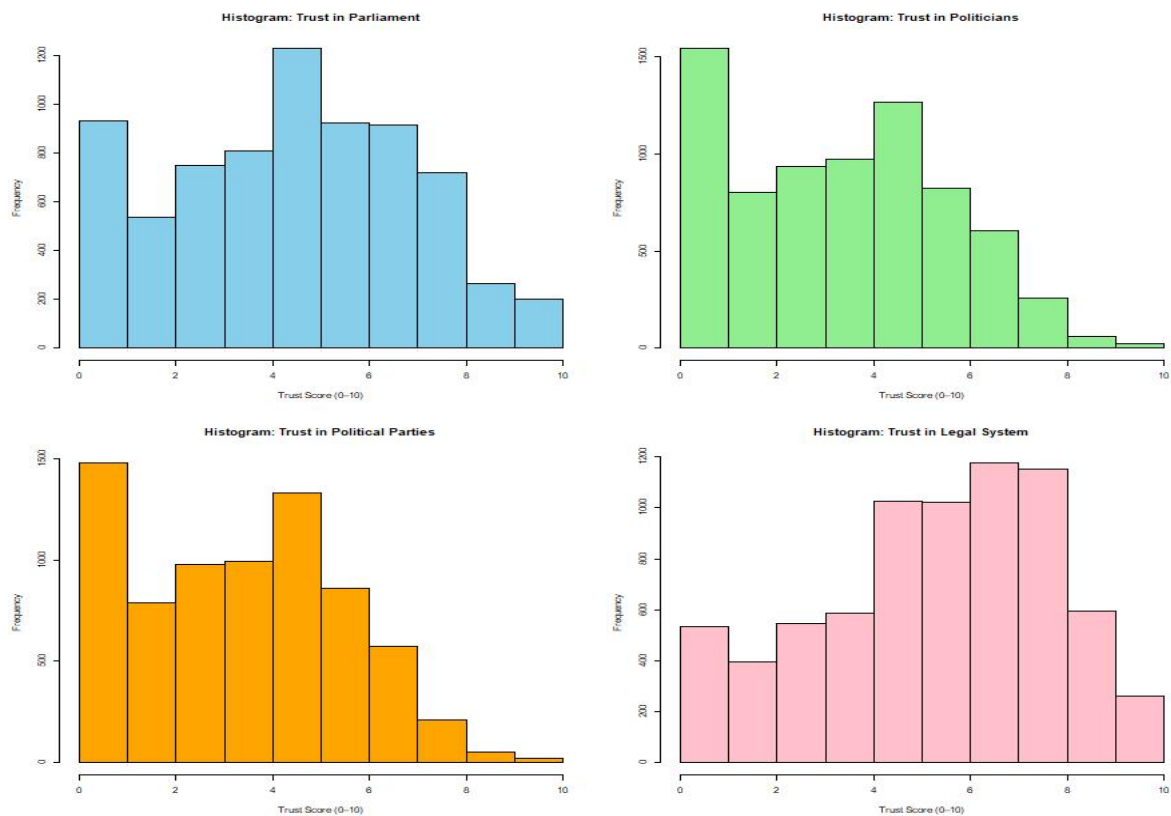
system ($\chi^2 = 909.08$, $p < .001$). Significant differences were also observed for age ($\chi^2 = 72.28$, $p < .001$) and years of education ($\chi^2 = 468.28$, $p < .001$). These results indicate substantial variation in institutional trust and respondent characteristics across Germany, Italy, Poland, and Sweden.

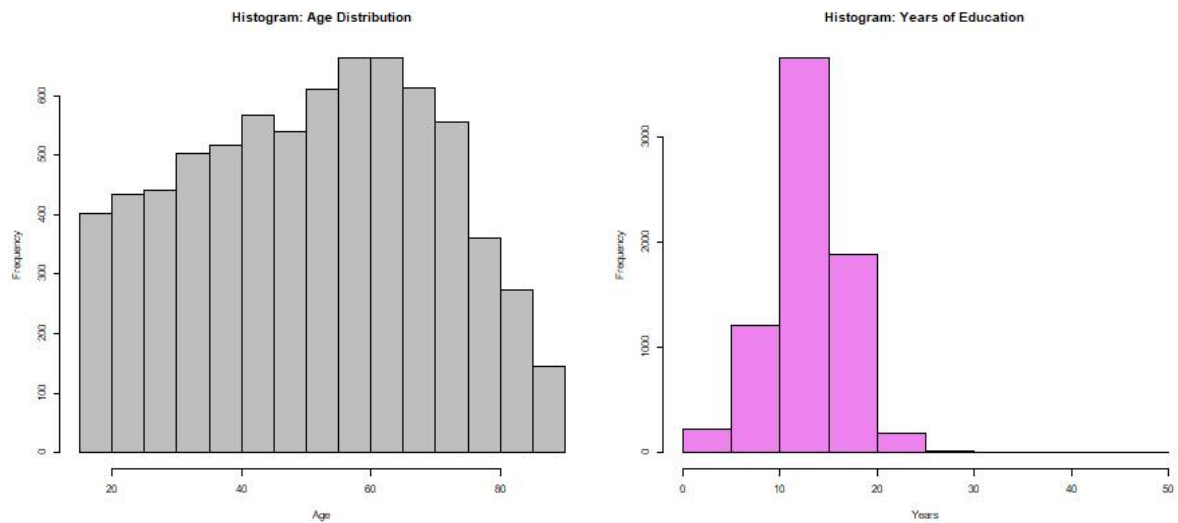
Table 3: Kruskal–Wallis Tests of Cross-Country Differences

Variable	χ^2	p-value	Result
Trust in Parliament	645.54	< .001	Significant
Trust in Politicians	537.02	< .001	Significant
Trust in Political Parties	617.14	< .001	Significant
Trust in Legal System	909.08	< .001	Significant
Age	72.28	< .001	Significant
Years of Education	468.28	< .001	Significant

Source: Authors' analysis of European Social Survey Round 11 data

Note. Kruskal–Wallis tests assess whether the distributions of the selected variables differ significantly across Germany, Italy, Poland, and Sweden.





Source: Authors' analysis of European Social Survey Round 11 data.

Overall, the descriptive and non-parametric results demonstrate substantial cross-national variation in institutional trust. The differences are particularly pronounced for trust in the legal system, which records the largest Kruskal–Wallis statistic among the four trust measures. These cross-country differences support the inclusion of country effects in the subsequent multivariate models, which examine whether political participation remains associated with institutional trust after accounting for national context and individual-level characteristic

4.2 Logistic Regression Analysis of Institutional Trust

Binary logistic regression models were estimated to examine the relationship between political participation and four dimensions of institutional trust: trust in parliament, politicians, political parties, and the legal system. To facilitate comparison across institutional outcomes, the results are presented according to model specification. The first models estimate the association between political participation and institutional trust while controlling for individual characteristics. The second incorporate country fixed effects to account for cross-national differences, while the third introduce interaction terms between political participation and political interest. This structure allows the consistency of the observed relationships to be assessed across all four measures of institutional trust.

4.2.1 Main Logistic Regression Models

The first set of models examines the associations between political participation and each dimension of institutional trust while controlling for individual demographic and socioeconomic characteristics. Table 4 presents the results for trust in parliament, politicians, political parties, and the legal system, allowing the direction and statistical significance of the associations to be compared across the four institutional outcomes.

Table4: Main Logistic Regression Models of Institutional Trust

Predictor	Parliament	Politicians	Political Parties	Legal System
Institutional participation				
Voted in last national election	0.589***	0.401***	0.418***	0.150*
Contacted politician/official	0.069	0.115	0.084	-0.087
Political party/action-group activity	0.301**	0.410***	0.450***	0.275*
Non-institutional participation				
Signed petition	0.051	-0.105	-0.102	0.237**
Lawful public demonstration	0.092	0.184*	0.207*	-0.036
Boycotted products	0.159*	-0.022	-0.084	0.285***
Posted/shared political content online	-0.202**	-0.205**	-0.178*	-0.252**
Political interest	-0.453***	-0.428***	-0.453***	-0.242***
Demographic controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Employment controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	6,796	6,796	6,796	6,796
AIC	8,581.7	8,884.7	8,814.4	7,943.1

Source: Authors' analysis of European Social Survey Round 11 data

Note. Entries are logistic regression coefficients. All models control for gender, religious affiliation, age, years of education, and employment status. Country effects are not included in these baseline models. * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

Analysis of Table 4

The baseline models reveal several patterns that are consistent across the four measures of institutional trust. Among institutionalised forms of participation, voting shows a positive and

statistically significant association with every trust outcome. The association is strongest for trust in parliament ($\beta = 0.589$, $p < .001$), followed by political parties and politicians, while the positive association with trust in the legal system is smaller. Political party activity follows a similar pattern, showing positive and significant associations across all four institutional outcomes. By contrast, contacting politicians or public officials is not statistically significant in any of the baseline models. These results therefore suggest that the relationship between institutional participation and trust is strongest for voting and direct party involvement rather than for all institutionalised activities uniformly.

The results for non-institutionalised participation are considerably more mixed. Online political sharing is the most consistent finding, displaying a negative and statistically significant association with all four trust outcomes. Other forms of non-institutional participation do not follow the same pattern. Demonstration participation is positively associated with trust in politicians and political parties, while boycotting is positively associated with trust in parliament and the legal system. Petition signing is positively associated with trust in the legal system but is not significant for the other outcomes. Consequently, the baseline models do not support a simple conclusion that non-institutional participation is generally associated with lower political trust.

Finally, Political interest is negatively associated with all four institutional trust outcomes. However, because the ESS political-interest variable is coded from 1 (very interested) to 4 (not at all interested), the negative coefficients indicate that respondents with lower levels of political interest are less likely to report high institutional trust. Conversely, greater political interest is associated with higher levels of trust in parliament, politicians, political parties, and the legal system.

4.2.2 Country Fixed Effects Models

The second set of models incorporates country fixed effects to account for systematic differences across Germany, Italy, Poland, and Sweden. Table 5 presents the fixed-effects estimates for all four dimensions of institutional trust. Germany serves as the reference country.

Table5: Country Fixed Effects Logistic Regression Models of Institutional Trust

Predictor	Parliament	Politicians	Political Parties	Legal System
Institutional participation				
Voted in last national election	0.581***	0.362***	0.383***	0.246**
Contacted politician/official	0.016	0.068	0.037	-0.192*
Political party/action-group activity	0.316**	0.422***	0.469***	0.297*
Non-institutional participation				

Predictor	Parliament	Politicians	Political Parties	Legal System
Signed petition	-0.004	-0.171*	-0.160*	0.132
Lawful public demonstration	0.244*	0.256**	0.287**	0.059
Boycotted products	-0.030	-0.118+	-0.174*	0.108
Posted/shared political content online	-0.320***	-0.292***	-0.251**	-0.414***
Political interest	-0.463***	-0.439***	-0.461***	-0.257***
Country effects				
Italy	0.130+	-0.010	0.061	0.014
Poland	-0.769***	-0.706***	-0.589***	-1.406***
Sweden	1.011***	0.677***	0.898***	0.538***
Demographic controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Employment controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	6,796	6,796	6,796	6,796
AIC	8,256.7	8,559.7	8,494.8	7,482.3

Source: Authors' analysis of European Social Survey Round 11 data.

Note. Entries are logistic regression coefficients. Germany is the reference country. All models control for gender, religious affiliation, political interest, age, years of education, and employment status. + $p < .10$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

Analysis of Table 5

After accounting for country differences, voting remains positively and significantly associated with all four dimensions of institutional trust. The association is strongest for trust in parliament ($\beta = 0.581$, $p < .001$), while positive relationships are also observed for politicians ($\beta = 0.362$, $p < .001$), political parties ($\beta = 0.383$, $p < .001$), and the legal system ($\beta = 0.246$, $p < .01$). Political party activity displays the same general pattern, remaining positively and significantly associated with all four trust outcomes. Contacting politicians or officials, however, is not significantly associated with the three explicitly political institutions and is negatively associated with trust in the legal system ($\beta = -0.192$, $p < .05$). Overall, the fixed-effects results provide partial support for H1, with the strongest and most consistent evidence coming from voting and political party activity.

Non-institutionalised participation continues to show a less uniform relationship with trust. Online political sharing is the only activity consistently associated with lower trust across all four outcomes, with negative coefficients for parliament ($\beta = -0.320$, $p < .001$), politicians ($\beta = -0.292$, $p < .001$), political parties ($\beta = -0.251$, $p < .01$), and the legal system ($\beta = -0.414$, $p < .001$). Petition signing is negatively associated with trust in politicians and political parties but is not significant for parliament or the legal system. Boycotting is

negatively associated with political-party trust and only marginally associated with politicians, whereas demonstrations are positively associated with trust in parliament, politicians, and political parties. These mixed results provide only partial support for H2 and show that non-institutional participation should not be treated as a single expression of institutional distrust.

Political interest remains negative and statistically significant across all four models. Because the ESS political-interest variable is coded from 1 (very interested) to 4 (not at all interested), these negative coefficients indicate that lower political interest is associated with a lower likelihood of reporting high institutional trust. Conversely, respondents with greater political interest are more likely to report high trust across the four institutional outcomes. The country fixed effects also reveal substantial cross-national differences, with Germany serving as the reference category. Respondents in Sweden have significantly higher odds of reporting high trust across all four institutional outcomes, whereas respondents in Poland have significantly lower odds of reporting high trust across all four outcomes relative to respondents in Germany. The largest negative country coefficient is observed for trust in the legal system in Poland ($\beta = -1.406$, $p < .001$). The coefficients for Italy are comparatively small and are not statistically significant at the conventional 5% level across the four outcomes.

The lower AIC values of the fixed-effects models compared with the corresponding main models indicate improved model fit after accounting for country-level differences. This reinforces the importance of national context in explaining variation in institutional trust across the four countries.

4.2.3 Political Interest Interaction Models

The third set of models introduces interaction terms between political participation and political interest to assess whether the relationship between participation and institutional trust varies according to respondents' level of political interest. Table 6 presents the interaction-model results for all four trust outcomes.

Table6: Political Interest Interaction Models of Institutional Trust

Predictor	Parliament	Politicians	Political Parties	Legal System
Institutional participation				
Voted in last national election	0.379	0.132	-0.005	0.479+
Contacted politician/official	-0.245	-0.243	-0.104	-0.376
Political party/action-group activity	0.132	0.514+	0.354	0.351

Predictor	Parliament	Politicians	Political Parties	Legal System
Non-institutional participation				
Signed petition	0.181	−0.102	−0.133	0.136
Lawful public demonstration	0.303	−0.058	0.233	−0.154
Boycotted products	−0.027	−0.045	−0.224	0.464*
Posted/shared political content online	−0.651**	−0.427*	−0.278	−0.725**
Political interest	−0.546***	−0.527***	−0.593***	−0.197*
Participation × political interest				
Vote × Political interest	0.067	0.076	0.130	−0.075
Contact × Political interest	0.137	0.161	0.075	0.091
Party activity × Political interest	0.116	−0.032	0.075	−0.016
Petition × Political interest	−0.088	−0.033	−0.013	−0.002
Demonstration × Political interest	−0.027	0.157	0.028	0.104
Boycott × Political interest	−0.003	−0.036	0.024	−0.161+
Online sharing × Political interest	0.162+	0.069	0.016	0.142
Country effects				
Italy	0.139+	−0.004	0.067	0.015
Poland	−0.761***	−0.697***	−0.586***	−1.397***
Sweden	1.019***	0.679***	0.900***	0.537***
Demographic controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Employment controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	6,796	6,796	6,796	6,796
AIC	8,262.5	8,566.7	8,504.5	7,489.5

Source: Authors' analysis of European Social Survey Round 11 data.

Note. Entries are logistic regression coefficients. Germany is the reference country. All models include demographic and employment controls. Interaction terms test whether political interest moderates the association between each form of participation and institutional trust. + $p < .10$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

Analysis of Table 6

The interaction models provide little evidence that political interest systematically moderates the relationship between political participation and institutional trust. Across the four outcomes, most interaction terms are statistically non-significant. For trust in parliament, only the interaction between online political sharing and political interest approaches statistical significance ($\beta = 0.162$, $p < .10$). For trust in the legal system, the interaction between boycotting and political interest is also only marginally significant ($\beta = -0.161$, $p < .10$). None of the interaction terms reaches conventional statistical significance for trust in politicians or political parties.

Political interest itself remains negatively associated with all four trust outcomes in the interaction models. Online political sharing also remains negatively associated with trust in parliament, politicians, and the legal system, while the coefficient for political parties is negative but not statistically significant. Country patterns remain stable: Sweden continues to show higher trust relative to Germany, whereas Poland continues to show substantially lower trust across all four institutional outcomes.

The interaction models also produce slightly higher AIC values than the corresponding country fixed-effects models for all four trust outcomes. This indicates that adding the interaction terms does not improve model fit sufficiently to justify the additional complexity. Taken together, the results provide little support for H3: political interest does not appear to consistently condition the relationship between political participation and institutional trust.

4.2.4 Odds Ratios and Average Marginal Effects

The odds ratios and average marginal effects generally reinforce the patterns observed in the logistic regression models. Voting is associated with higher predicted institutional trust, with odds ratios of 1.787 for parliament, 1.444 for politicians, and 1.502 for political parties. Political party activity similarly shows positive associations across these outcomes. In contrast, online political engagement is associated with lower institutional trust, with odds ratios below one for parliament (0.726), politicians (0.809), and political parties (0.853). Political interest also displays a consistent association across the three outcomes, with odds ratios of approximately 0.63–0.64. Given that political interest is coded from 1 (very interested) to 4 (not at all interested), these values indicate that movement toward lower political interest is associated with lower odds of reporting high institutional trust.

The average marginal effects provide a similar substantive interpretation. Voting is associated with an approximately 11.9 percentage-point increase in the predicted probability of high parliamentary trust, 8.2 percentage points for trust in politicians, and 9.0 percentage points for trust in political parties. Online political engagement is associated with reductions of approximately 6.5, 4.7, and 3.5 percentage points, respectively. A one-category movement toward lower political interest is associated with a reduction of approximately 9.6–10.4 percentage points in the predicted probability of high institutional trust across these three outcomes. These results reinforce the distinction between conventional institutional participation and online political engagement observed in the regression analysis.

4.3 Exploratory Factor Analysis

After the logistic regression analysis, the study conducted an exploratory factor analysis (EFA) to examine whether the political participation and institutional trust indicators clustered into broader underlying dimensions. The analysis included eight variables: voting, contacting a politician or government official, signing a petition, participating in a public demonstration, and trust in parliament, politicians, political parties, and the legal system. The EFA was based on the cleaned sample of 7,286 respondents.

4.3.1 Factor Structure

The three-factor solution explained 49% of the total variance. Factor 1 accounted for 36% of the variance, Factor 2 for an additional 9%, and Factor 3 for 4%. The strongest and clearest structure emerged for the institutional trust variables. Trust in parliament and politicians each loaded at 0.91 on Factor 1, while trust in political parties loaded at 0.88 and trust in the legal system at 0.63. These results indicate a strong common dimension of institutional trust.

Political participation was more strongly represented by Factor 2. Petition signing recorded the largest loading (0.62), followed by participation in demonstrations (0.39) and contacting politicians or officials (0.37). Voting showed a weaker loading of 0.18. This factor therefore reflects a broader dimension of civic or participatory action, although its structure is less pronounced than the institutional-trust factor.

Table7: Exploratory Factor Analysis of Political Participation and Institutional Trust

Variable	Factor 1	Factor 2	Factor 3
Voted in last national election	−0.09	0.18	−0.03
Contacted politician/government official	−0.13	0.37	0.02

Variable	Factor 1	Factor 2	Factor 3
Signed petition	−0.16	0.62	0.00
Participated in public demonstration	−0.10	0.39	0.03
Trust in parliament	0.91	0.05	0.41
Trust in politicians	0.91	0.09	−0.23
Trust in political parties	0.88	0.07	−0.24
Trust in legal system	0.63	0.02	0.08
SS loadings	2.90	0.73	0.29
Proportion of variance	0.36	0.09	0.04
Cumulative variance	0.36	0.45	0.49

Source: Authors' analysis of European Social Survey Round 11 data.

Note. Factor loadings are based on the three-factor exploratory solution reported in the original analysis. Bold values identify the principal loadings used to interpret Factors 1 and 2.

4.3.2 Interpretation

The factor analysis provides additional evidence that institutional trust constitutes a relatively coherent underlying dimension. Trust in parliament, politicians, and political parties loads particularly strongly on the first factor, while trust in the legal system also contributes to this dimension, although with a comparatively smaller loading. This pattern is consistent with the regression analysis, which treats the four trust measures as related but distinct institutional outcomes.

The participation indicators form a weaker second dimension, driven particularly by petition signing, demonstrations, and political contact. Factor 3 explains only 4% of the total variance and does not exhibit a sufficiently clear pattern of loadings to support a substantive interpretation. The main interpretable result of the EFA is therefore the distinction between a strong institutional-trust dimension and a weaker civic-action dimension.

5. Discussion

The findings demonstrate that the relationship between political participation and institutional trust is more complex than a simple distinction between trusting institutional participants and

distrustful non-institutional participants. Across the four measures of trust, some relationships are highly consistent, particularly for voting, political party activity, online political engagement, political interest, and country context. Other forms of participation show different associations depending on the institution being considered. Overall, the results provide partial support for H1 and H2, but little support for H3.

5.1 Institutional Participation and Political Trust

The strongest support for H1 comes from voting and political party activity. Both are positively and significantly associated with trust in parliament, politicians, political parties, and the legal system after controlling for country and individual characteristics. This pattern suggests that citizens who engage through established democratic channels tend to report higher levels of institutional trust. It is consistent with the distinction between institutionalised and non-institutionalised political participation developed in the theoretical framework and with previous research emphasising the relationship between political trust and conventional forms of participation, particularly Hooghe and Marien (2013).

However, the results do not indicate that every institutionalised form of participation is positively related to trust. Contacting politicians or public officials is largely insignificant and is negatively associated with trust in the legal system in the country fixed-effects model. H1 should therefore be regarded as partially rather than fully supported. The evidence is strongest for voting and political party involvement, suggesting that different forms of institutional participation should not be treated as interchangeable.

5.2 Non-Institutional Participation and Critical Engagement

H2 receives more limited support. The clearest finding is the consistent negative association between online political sharing and all four dimensions of institutional trust. Even after country differences are incorporated, online political engagement remains negatively associated with trust in parliament, politicians, political parties, and the legal system. This suggests that digital political participation may provide an important channel through which politically engaged citizens express criticism or dissatisfaction with established institutions.

Other forms of non-institutional participation, however, do not display a consistently negative relationship with trust. Demonstration participation is positively associated with trust in parliament, politicians, and political parties in the fixed-effects models. Petition signing is negatively associated with trust in politicians and political parties but not with parliament or the legal system, while boycotting also produces mixed results. These findings challenge the assumption that participation outside conventional institutions necessarily reflects political distrust.

Instead, the results are more compatible with the idea of critical citizenship, whereby citizens may participate actively while simultaneously evaluating political institutions critically. This interpretation is consistent with Norris's (1999) argument that scepticism toward political institutions does not necessarily translate into political withdrawal. Non-institutional participation may therefore reflect different motivations, ranging from dissatisfaction to active democratic engagement, depending on the specific activity involved.

5.3 Political Interest and the Moderation Hypothesis

Political interest produces one of the most consistent findings in the analysis. It is negatively and significantly associated with all four measures of institutional trust across the main, country fixed-effects, and interaction models. However, because the ESS political-interest variable is coded from 1 (very interested) to 4 (not at all interested), the negative coefficients indicate that lower political interest is associated with lower institutional trust. Conversely, respondents with greater political interest tend to report higher levels of institutional trust. This relationship remains consistent after accounting for country differences and the other individual-level characteristics included in the models.

However, political interest does not consistently moderate the relationship between participation and trust. Most participation $\times$ political-interest interactions are statistically non-significant, with only isolated marginal relationships appearing in the models. Furthermore, the interaction specifications do not improve model fit relative to the country fixed-effects models. Consequently, H3 is not supported by the analysis. Political interest appears more important as an independent correlate of institutional trust than as a systematic moderator of the participation–trust relationship..

5.4 Cross-National Differences

The country effects demonstrate that national political context remains important even after individual characteristics and political participation are taken into account. Relative to Germany, Sweden consistently records higher institutional trust, whereas Poland consistently records lower trust across parliament, politicians, political parties, and the legal system. The particularly large negative coefficient for Poland in the legal-system model suggests that cross-national differences extend beyond explicitly political institutions to broader institutional confidence. Italy, by contrast, shows relatively small differences from Germany once individual characteristics and participation are controlled.

These results broadly support the comparative rationale of the study, particularly the contrast between Sweden and Poland. They also demonstrate why political trust should not be analysed solely as an individual-level phenomenon. Institutional and national contexts appear to shape the levels of trust within which individual political participation occurs.

5.5 Overall Interpretation

Taken together, the findings suggest that the relationship between political participation and institutional trust depends substantially on how citizens participate. Voting and political party activity are consistently associated with higher trust, while online political sharing is consistently associated with lower trust. Other forms of participation occupy a less straightforward position and may represent forms of engagement that cannot be classified simply as either trust-driven or distrust-driven.

The findings therefore refine the original theoretical expectations. H1 receives partial support, particularly through voting and political party activity. H2 also receives partial support, but mainly through online political engagement rather than non-institutional participation as a whole. H3 receives little empirical support, as political interest does not consistently moderate the relationship between participation and trust. These results reinforce the value of analysing individual forms of political participation separately rather than assuming that institutionalised and non-institutionalised activities constitute internally uniform categories.

6. Conclusion and Policy Implications

This study examined the relationship between political participation and trust in political institutions across Germany, Italy, Poland, and Sweden using data from the European Social Survey Round 11. By distinguishing between different forms of institutionalised and non-institutionalised political participation and examining four dimensions of institutional trust—parliament, politicians, political parties, and the legal system—the analysis demonstrates that the participation–trust relationship varies substantially according to the type of political activity considered.

The findings provide partial support for the expectation that institutionalised political participation is positively associated with political trust. Voting and political party activity show the most consistent positive relationships with institutional trust across the regression models. Contacting politicians or public officials, however, does not demonstrate the same pattern. Similarly, the expectation that non-institutionalised participation is associated with lower trust receives only partial support. Online political engagement is consistently associated with lower institutional trust, whereas petitions, demonstrations, and boycotts produce more varied relationships across institutions. These findings suggest that conventional and non-conventional political participation cannot be understood as internally homogeneous categories.

The analysis also finds limited evidence that political interest moderates the relationship between participation and institutional trust. Most interaction effects are statistically insignificant, and the interaction models do not improve model fit relative to the country fixed-effects specifications. The third hypothesis is therefore not supported. At the same time,

the substantial country differences identified in both the descriptive and multivariate analyses demonstrate the importance of national context. Sweden consistently records higher institutional trust relative to Germany, while Poland records lower trust, with particularly pronounced differences in trust in the legal system.

These findings have several implications for democratic governance. First, policymakers should avoid interpreting declining institutional trust simply as evidence of political disengagement. Citizens with critical views of political institutions may remain politically active, particularly through digital and other non-institutional channels. Governments and democratic institutions should therefore consider such participation not only as a sign of dissatisfaction but also as a potential source of information about citizens' concerns and evaluations of institutional performance.

Second, the results highlight the continued importance of established channels of democratic participation. The positive associations observed for voting and political party activity suggest that accessible and credible institutional channels remain relevant to the relationship between citizens and political institutions. Strengthening opportunities for meaningful citizen involvement, responsiveness, and communication may therefore contribute to maintaining democratic engagement. At the same time, the negative association between online political engagement and trust suggests that institutions need to pay greater attention to how citizens encounter, discuss, and evaluate politics in digital environments.

Finally, the strong cross-national differences indicate that policies intended to strengthen political trust should be sensitive to institutional context. A uniform approach is unlikely to produce identical outcomes across countries with different political and institutional environments. Measures aimed at improving institutional responsiveness, transparency, accountability, and citizen participation should therefore reflect the specific national context in which distrust or disengagement occurs.

The study nevertheless has limitations. The use of cross-sectional ESS Round 11 data means that the analysis identifies associations rather than causal relationships. It cannot determine whether political participation influences institutional trust, whether trust influences participation, or whether both are shaped by other factors. The dichotomisation of the trust measures also simplifies variation within the original 0–10 scales. In addition, the four-country design provides useful comparative variation but does not represent the full diversity of European democracies. Future research could use longitudinal or repeated cross-sectional ESS data to examine how the participation–trust relationship changes over time, extend the analysis to a larger group of countries, and investigate individual forms of digital political participation in greater detail.

Overall, the study demonstrates that political participation and institutional trust are connected, but the direction and strength of this relationship depend on the form of participation, the institution being evaluated, and the national context. Rather than treating

political participation as a single behaviour or political distrust as equivalent to disengagement, research and policy should recognise the multiple ways in which citizens interact with democratic institutions. This more differentiated perspective provides a stronger basis for understanding political engagement and institutional trust in contemporary European democracies.

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